

THE CREATURE BEFORE GOD

Part II

The Due Return

Religion and the Justice of Creaturehood

From unowed gift and commanded good
to hope and the freedom of a living sacrifice

Contents

1	The Question after Vertigo	1
2	The Gift That Cannot Be Repaid	1
3	Justice without Equivalence	2
4	A Grammar of “Have To”	3
5	Gift before Command	4
6	The Layers of Law	5
7	Sunday: The Due Made Common	7
8	Failure Is Not Yet a Judgment of the Person	8
9	The Grace of the Answer	9
A	Scope, Method, and Qualifications	10
B	References	12
C	Generation Metadata	13

1 The Question after Vertigo

The first movement reached two judgments: *I am, and I am not from myself*; the source who needs nothing freely wills created good—God loves. Neither judgment waits for permission. A creature depends upon its source before it understands, welcomes, or resists that dependence. Yet the truth, once apprehended, addresses a power that can answer. The question passes from being to will: *what is due from one who has received everything by which an answer can be made?*

St. Paul places the question within an apparent contradiction. “Who has given [God] anything that he may be repaid?” The answer is no one. “From him and through him and for him are all things” (Rom 11:35–36). No creature reaches behind the first gift, supplies a divine lack, or makes God its debtor. Paul then draws a practical conclusion: “therefore,” by the mercies of God, offer your bodies as a living sacrifice and spiritual worship (Rom 12:1). The denial of repayment does not end the return. It purifies it.

The distinction is exact. Before I existed, being was not owed to me. Because I exist from God and for God, worship is owed by me. The second sentence does not reverse the first. Creation is not a contract in which a recipient first accepts goods and later receives an invoice. The due arises within the real order established by the gift: a rational creature can recognize its first principle and last end, and can direct its acts accordingly.

Governing thesis

The unowed gift of creaturehood establishes a real but unequal due. The rational creature ought freely to acknowledge God as first principle and last end, through worship and through justice toward the neighbor. Natural and revealed law articulate that order; ecclesiastical law specifies parts of its common practice for defined subjects; grace enables the answer without erasing its obligation. Charity does not abolish what is due. It gives the due its filial form.

The title *due return* therefore names neither equivalent repayment nor an exchange of benefits. It names a morally fitting response to a relation that is already true. God receives no actuality from it. The creature does. By acknowledging the Creator, the creature does not add a perfection to God; it orders its own intellect, will, body, time, possessions, and common life to the truth of their source.

Ontological dependence and moral obligation must nevertheless remain distinct. Dependence is the fact; obligation concerns the fitting act of a rational will. Sin can reject the order of the due, but it cannot repeal creaturehood. Conversely, metaphysics alone does not specify every commandment, sacrament, holy day, or ecclesiastical precept. The movement from dependence to a concrete Christian life passes through natural reason, revelation, covenant, the authority of the Church, prudence, and grace.

That movement is the subject of this article. It begins with the impossibility of putting God in our debt. It asks how justice can govern a return that can never be equal; why obligation need not mean coercion; how the Decalogue, natural law, divine law, and ecclesiastical precept differ; and how the Sunday obligation gives one concrete form to the worship owed to God. It ends where justice reaches its limit: not with the cancellation of duty, but with the hope that the Giver also gives the power to answer.

2 The Gift That Cannot Be Repaid

2.1 No divine lack to fill

The first error is to imagine worship as divine maintenance. If praise, sacrifice, or obedience completed God, the Creator would depend upon the creature in the very order the creature is asked to acknowledge. The asymmetry would collapse.

Irenaeus rejects that picture directly. God did not form Adam because he needed a human being upon whom to depend. Before creation, the Word glorified the Father. Nor did God command service because he needed human obedience. Those who follow the light do not illuminate it; they are illuminated. Service profits God nothing, while the servant receives life, incorruption, and communion with God (*Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2). The point governs Irenaeus’s treatment of sacrifice as well. God does not hunger for oblations. He teaches a people to turn from idols, to practice justice, and to offer from a rightly ordered heart (IV.17.1; 18.1–6).

This is not a merely negative conclusion. Divine non-need explains why command can be beneficent without becoming self-interested. We do not serve because God lacks. We serve because we lack God. The command establishes no profit in the one commanding; it directs the commanded toward communion with the good it cannot produce for itself.

Aquinas reaches the same point through the virtue of religion. We offer to God not for his usefulness but for his glory and our good (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 6, ad 2). “Glory” here is not an increase in divine excellence. It is the creature’s manifestation and acknowledgment of an excellence already infinite. Right worship makes no new truth about God; it makes the worshipper’s act true.

2.2 A due established within gift

If God owes no creature the original gift of existence, how can a due arise at all? Aquinas distinguishes the orders carefully. God is not directed to creatures as to an end that perfects him. Within the order willed by divine wisdom, however, God gives each created nature what belongs to its condition; created dues are real but derivative (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3). The creature likewise possesses goods, powers, relations, and ends from which genuine obligations follow.

The due return therefore begins after the gift, not before it. A nonexistent recipient has no antecedent claim to be created. An existing rational creature is nevertheless capable of acting fittingly or unfittingly toward the source from whom it exists. It can acknowledge truth or suppress it, honor the good or prefer a lesser good as ultimate, render justice or withhold it.

This avoids two opposite errors. The first turns gift into contract: God gives in order to exact an equivalent. The second turns gift into moral indifference: because the gift was free, no response can be owed. A gift need not create commercial equivalence in order to establish a relation with moral form. The child’s debt of honor to a parent, for example, is neither payment for conception nor a claim that parental goodness needs completion. The analogy is limited, but it shows why gratuity and due are not contraries.

The relation to God is more radical and less commensurable. Everything offered is already received: the body that kneels, the reason that judges, the will that consents, the bread and wine placed upon the altar, the hour reserved for worship. Nothing crosses from an independent estate into divine possession. The return cannot make the accounts equal because there are no such accounts.

The paradox of the due

Being was not owed to me. I cannot repay it. Yet because I exist from God and for God, I owe the truthful use of what I have received.

The due cannot be paid off. It can only be lived.

3 Justice without Equivalence

3.1 The will to render the due

Aquinas receives the classical juristic definition of justice as the constant and enduring will to render to each one his right. The definition joins an objective term—what is due to another—to a subjective firmness—the will that knowingly and steadily renders it (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 1). Justice is not satisfied by a correct idea retained within the intellect. It rectifies action toward another.

God is not “another” alongside creatures within one common genus. Yet a rational creature is really distinct from God and really ordered to him. The special virtue governing acts of honor toward God is religion. It offers sacrifice, adoration, prayer, vows, and related acts because God alone is the first principle of creation and government and the last end of rational life (ST II–II, q. 81, aa. 1–4).

Religion belongs to justice, but not as a part capable of exact equality. Aquinas places it among justice’s potential parts: something is genuinely due, but the full equality of strict justice cannot be achieved because the recipient infinitely exceeds the giver and the return can never equal the gift (q. 80, a. 1; q. 81, a. 5). The shortfall is not a defect in a willing creature’s virtue. Equality is measured according to the creature’s capacity and God’s acceptance,

not as equivalence between independent parties (q. 81, a. 5, ad 3).

An equal return is impossible. A true return is not.

3.2 Obligation without coercion

The word *obligation* often acquires the sound of an alien will pressing upon one's own. That picture confuses moral necessity with force. Aquinas distinguishes a necessity arising from constraint, which acts against the will, from the necessity of a command or of a means required for an end. The second does not destroy merit when one voluntarily does what is necessary (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 3, ad 2). Likewise, the service owed to God can be virtuous precisely insofar as it is rendered willingly (q. 81, a. 2, ad 2).

Duty is therefore neither self-creation nor alien coercion. The will does not invent the good by choosing it, but neither is a forced bodily movement an act of virtue. A just act is knowingly chosen for a due end and performed with stability. Obligation can bind the will without forcing it.

This distinction explains why consent—free agreement with the truth—is stronger than mere compliance. The Creator's authority is not produced by consent; nevertheless, the creature's moral act becomes whole only through consent. A person can appear at worship from fear of reputation, recite words without attention, or avoid external wrongdoing while inwardly preferring injustice. The external act may retain some objective order, but virtue requires the will's truthful participation.

Aquinas calls the will's readiness for divine service *devotion*. Devotion is not first an intensity of feeling. It is the act by which one gives oneself readily to what pertains to God's service (ST II–II, q. 82, aa. 1–2). It thus stands at the border between justice and charity. Justice identifies the due; devotion names a will becoming ready to render it; charity will disclose how service can be animated by friendship with God.

3.3 Religion, faith, hope, and charity

Religion is not itself a theological virtue. Its immediate acts are things offered in divine worship; God is their end. Faith, hope, and charity have God himself as their proper object and can command religion's acts (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 5). These distinctions prevent the trilogy's movements from becoming three sealed compartments.

Faith receives God's truth and recognizes whom worship addresses. Hope relies upon divine help for communion and beatitude. Charity loves God for God's sake and directs the other virtues to their final end. Religion gives embodied and common form to their worship. One Mass may therefore be at once commanded by ecclesiastical law, an act of religion, formed by charity, sustained by hope, and expressive of faith. The distinctions do not divide the person. They show why "having to go" says too little about what the act can be.

Justice asks what belongs to another. Religion asks what belongs to God alone. Charity will not answer by declaring that nothing is owed. It will make the due filial.

4 A Grammar of "Have To"

One phrase can conceal several kinds of necessity. "I have to" may report an unchosen fact, a moral judgment, a juridical command, or external compulsion. A clear account must separate them before reconnecting them.

Five terms

Dependence

What is true whether or not I consent. A creature receives being; refusal cannot make it uncreated.

Duty

What ought to be chosen. Moral obligation addresses a rational and voluntary power; it binds without physically compelling it.

Precept

A duty, or a determinate mode of fulfilling one, commanded by competent authority for identified subjects and

circumstances.

Culpability

Personal responsibility for a concrete failure, judged with knowledge, freedom, intention, matter, and relevant circumstances distinguished.

Counsel

A good proposed beyond universal precept as a freer means to perfection; it never licenses neglect of what justice already requires.

The taxonomy is this article's synthesis. Its components are traditional, but the sequence protects several boundaries at once.

Dependence is ontological. It is neither a statute nor a moral achievement. Duty is moral: the order of reason identifies an act as fitting and binds the will without physically determining it. A precept adds the act of a lawgiver. It may state a duty already knowable in substance, or determine how a general duty is to be observed in common. Culpability concerns the responsible agent in a concrete act; it cannot be read directly from the bare statement of a rule. A counsel proposes a genuine good without converting every omission into injustice (ST I-II, q. 108, a. 4; CCC 1973–1974).

The distinctions explain why several common inferences fail. “I depend upon God” does not by itself yield the current Latin canon specifying when Sunday Mass participation satisfies an ecclesiastical precept. “The Church commands this act” does not mean every person who fails externally is equally culpable. “This act is counseled” does not mean it is morally trivial. “This act is owed” does not mean it is coerced or incapable of love.

4.1 Relief is not evasion

Positive law also recognizes that a general command meets particular facts. Three further terms are needed.

An *excuse* arises when relevant circumstances—for example, impossibility or a sufficiently serious reason under the applicable norm—mean that a person is not required to perform the act in the ordinary manner. A *dispensation* is an act of competent authority relaxing a merely ecclesiastical law in a particular case. A *commutation* replaces an obligation with another work where the law and competent authority permit it. These are not three names for private preference.

In the Sunday example, CIC c. 1248 §2 addresses impossibility because of the absence of a sacred minister or another grave cause. The *Catechism* names illness and care of infants as examples of serious reason (CCC 2181). CIC c. 1245 permits a pastor, for a just cause and under the diocesan bishop's prescriptions, to dispense in individual cases from observance of a feast day or commute it into another pious work; diocesan bishops retain their power under c. 87. The cause, authority, subject, and effect must not be blurred.

This grammar changes the sound of “what you have to do now.” The phrase no longer means a flat inventory of demands. It asks a sequence of questions: What relation is already true? What good is morally due? Has revelation or competent authority specified its form? To whom does the norm apply? What facts affect obligation? With what knowledge and freedom did the person act? Is the act commanded, counseled, excused, dispensed, or commuted?

The questions do not weaken obligation. They identify it.

5 Gift before Command

5.1 The indicative comes first

The Decalogue does not begin with a naked imperative. God first identifies himself through an act of deliverance: “I, the Lord, am your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, that place of slavery.” Only then follows “You shall” (Exod 20:2–3). At Sinai, covenantal gift precedes commanded response. The law does not address an anonymous will in an empty universe. It addresses a people already created, rescued, assembled, and claimed.

The order does not reduce command to gratitude. The commandments state genuine goods and prohibit genuine

evils. Nor does it make obedience the price by which liberation is purchased after the fact. It shows the identity of the Lawgiver and the relation within which the law is heard. The one who commands is not Pharaoh under another name. He is the one who has broken Pharaoh's claim.

The *Catechism* preserves this order. The Decalogue is understood within covenant and as a response to God's initiative; moral existence answers a loving action that comes first (CCC 2060–2062). The first word recalls liberation before it makes the just demand that Israel accept and worship the one God (CCC 2084). Command is not severed from gift, and gift is not made morally mute.

5.2 Natural law disclosed and taught

The commandments are revealed, yet their moral substance is not arbitrary. Aquinas argues that the moral precepts of the Old Law belong to the natural law: they concern acts whose order to human good can be known by reason (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 1). Revelation gives them divine promulgation, gathers them into covenant, corrects a reason darkened in practice, and directs them within salvation history.

This double character matters. One cannot say that theft or murder became wrong only when words were inscribed on tablets. Neither can one treat revelation as superfluous because reason can in principle know moral truth. Human beings require instruction, correction, authority, and grace. The Decalogue states with divine clarity an order that belongs to the good of rational creatures.

Aquinas treats its precepts as primary specifications of justice. The general commands to love God and neighbor order the whole law; the Decalogue gives immediately knowable conclusions and directs acts toward the due (q. 100, a. 3). The first table orders the person to the common and final good, God. The second establishes justice among persons, forbidding what is undue and commanding that each receive the due (q. 100, a. 8).

The division blocks a false piety. Religion directs acts to God's honor, but it can command works elicited by other virtues: mercy to the afflicted, temperance, truthfulness, and justice toward the neighbor (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 1, ad 1; a. 4, ad 1). One cannot honor the Creator by treating the creature's due as dispensable. The unseen God tests professed love in the treatment of the visible brother (1 John 4:20–21).

The two directions of the due

The first table forbids the creature to lie about God. The second forbids it to lie about the dignity and due of another creature. The same received life is ordered upward in worship and outward in justice.

5.3 Moral substance and specified observance

The Sabbath command displays another distinction. For Aquinas, its moral core is that a person should reserve some time for divine things. The determination of a particular time and ceremonial manner does not follow from natural reason alone (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 3, ad 2; a. 7, ad 5; II–II, q. 122, a. 4). The Christian Lord's Day is not therefore a simple continuation of every Mosaic Sabbath determination. Sunday commemorates Christ's Resurrection, fulfills the Sabbath's spiritual truth, and receives a definite common form in apostolic tradition and ecclesiastical law (CCC 2174–2177).

This is the first example of a pattern that will govern the legal analysis. A general moral due can be stable while its revealed and juridical determination requires additional sources. The obligation to worship does not by itself tell a reader which day, liturgy, subjects, exceptions, and competent authorities current law identifies. Metaphysics establishes no hidden canon. The due becomes concrete through several ordered forms of law.

6 The Layers of Law

6.1 Not four equal boxes

Law is an ordinance of reason for the common good, made and promulgated by one who has care of the community (ST I–II, q. 90). Within Aquinas's architecture, eternal law, natural law, divine law, and human law do not name four

independent legislatures occupying one plane.

Eternal law is divine wisdom ordering acts and ends. *Natural law* is the rational creature's participation in that order through practical reason. Its first precept is that good is to be done and pursued and evil avoided; further precepts follow the goods and relations of human nature (ST I–II, q. 94, a. 2). *Divine positive law* is used here for precepts known because God has revealed and promulgated them within the economy of salvation. *Human positive law*, civil or ecclesiastical, makes determinations for a community through competent authority.

The labels therefore answer different questions. Is the norm knowable through practical reason? Has God revealed or commanded it? Has human authority enacted a common determination? A single practice can stand under more than one description without the sources becoming interchangeable. Theological reasons do not by themselves create the juridical effect of a canon; a juridical command does not exhaust the moral or sacramental good it protects.

6.2 From a general due to a common form

Aquinas gives a terse account of the passage from natural due to positive determination. Natural reason dictates that the human person do something in reverence for God. That *this* rather than *that* determinate act be required can be established by divine or human law (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3). Sacrifice likewise belongs generically to natural law, while its concrete signs are determined by God or human authority (q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).

The same structure appears in the Lord's Day. The natural moral command requires outward, visible, public, and regular worship as acknowledgment of God's universal beneficence (CCC 2176). Revelation identifies Christ's Resurrection and the Eucharistic form of Christian worship. Apostolic tradition gives Sunday its Paschal identity. Ecclesiastical law states which faithful are bound, what satisfies the precept, and how impossibility and dispensation are treated.

Sunday is thus not a natural-law theorem. Neither is it an arbitrary weekly tax upon private time. It is the Paschal, apostolic, and ecclesially specified fulfillment of a natural moral due.

Positive determination is necessary because persons worship in a body, a household, and a Church. A purely private intention cannot by itself establish a common feast, assemble a parish, protect shared rest, or secure regular access to the Eucharistic celebration. Law gives stable public form to goods that isolated choice cannot coordinate. The precepts of the Church describe a necessary minimum in prayer, sacramental life, moral effort, and growth in love of God and neighbor (CCC 2041). A minimum is not the measure of holiness; it is a common floor beneath which ecclesial life is gravely injured.

6.3 Authority, persons, and facts

A precept is concrete only when its legal identity is known. One must identify the legislator, promulgated text, jurisdiction, persons bound, effective date, material facts, and any exception, dispensation, particular law, or later amendment. General theological statements cannot supply these data.

The Code itself sometimes marks the layers. CIC c. 1249 says that divine law binds all the Christian faithful to penance, then explains that common penitential days are prescribed so that the faithful may be united in shared observance. Canons 1250–1253 determine days, ages, and the competence of episcopal conferences. The underlying duty and its ecclesiastical specification are related but not identical.

The same discipline governs Sunday. The divine and moral reasons for worship do not eliminate the need to read CIC cc. 1246–1248. Conversely, those canons should not be read as if a three-line juridical text created the Resurrection, the Eucharist, or the virtue of religion. Law states an obligation within a reality it did not originate.

This article therefore turns to one bounded legal example. The controlling body of law is the 1983 Code of Canon Law as amended, for the Latin Church, under universal law as of 20 July 2026. The official Latin controls; the Holy See's English web rendering is a working reference. Particular territorial determinations and individual cases remain outside the conclusion.

7 Sunday: The Due Made Common

7.1 A Paschal obligation

Sunday is first the Lord's Day. Christ rose on the first day of the week; the Christian assembly receives that day as the first feast and the sign of the new creation (CCC 2174). The Church's weekly gathering is attested in the apostolic age and in early Christian witness. St. Justin Martyr describes Christians assembling on the day called Sunday for readings, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving, Communion, and aid to those in need (*First Apology* 67). Worship and mercy already belong to one act of the gathered body.

The Second Vatican Council calls Sunday the original feast day and directs that it be taught and observed as a day of joy and freedom from work (*Sacrosanctum Concilium* 106). The current canon does not invent this history. It gives the tradition universal juridical form in the Latin Church.

7.2 The controlling Latin law

CIC c. 1 limits the Code to the Latin Church. Under c. 11, merely ecclesiastical laws bind those baptized in the Catholic Church or received into it who possess sufficient use of reason and, unless the law provides otherwise, have completed seven years of age. These general norms control the apparently unqualified word “faithful” in the feast-day canons.

Canon 1246 §1 identifies Sunday, on which the Paschal mystery is celebrated by apostolic tradition, as the primordial holy day of obligation in the universal Church. It also lists other holy days. Under §2 an episcopal conference, with the prior approval of the Apostolic See, may suppress some of those other holy days or transfer them to Sunday. Consequently, a universal article cannot give one territorially complete calendar of holy days beyond Sunday.

Canon 1247 states two obligations. On Sundays and other holy days of obligation, the faithful are obliged to participate in Mass. They are also to abstain from works and affairs that hinder the worship owed to God, the joy proper to the Lord's Day, or suitable relaxation of mind and body. The second duty is not a generic ban on employment or exertion. Its objects—worship, festal joy, and humane rest—govern its meaning.

Canon 1248 §1 states what satisfies the Mass precept: assistance at a Mass celebrated anywhere in a Catholic rite, either on the feast itself or in the evening of the preceding day. The law requires participation in Mass; it does not by that precept require reception of Holy Communion on every Sunday. Reception is governed separately by the sacramental canons and the person's condition (CIC cc. 912–923).

Section 2 addresses a different case. If the absence of a sacred minister or another grave cause makes participation in the Eucharistic celebration impossible, the law strongly recommends participation in a liturgy of the Word celebrated according to the diocesan bishop's prescriptions, or prayer for a suitable time personally, in a family, or in groups of families. The recommended alternative is spiritually serious, but the text does not rename it a Mass or declare it performance of the impossible act.

7.3 Excuse, dispensation, and rest

The *Catechism* reads these canons within moral theology. The faithful are obliged to participate unless excused for a serious reason—illness and care of infants are given as examples—or dispensed by their pastor (CCC 2181). Canon 1245 permits a pastor, for a just cause and according to the diocesan bishop's prescriptions, to dispense in an individual case from observance of a feast day or to commute the obligation into another pious work. The diocesan bishop's broader power under c. 87 and the general law of dispensations in cc. 85–93 remain controlling.

The duty of rest also has limits. Family needs and important social service can legitimately excuse from Sunday rest (CCC 2185). Works of mercy belong positively to the day; Christians should also avoid imposing unnecessary work upon others and should attend to those whose poverty denies them ordinary leisure (CCC 2186–2187). The day is not sanctified by making necessary care invisible.

The distinctions prevent both laxity and rigorism. Private inconvenience is not automatically grave cause. A serious reason is not contempt for the precept. Dispensation is not self-dispensation. Necessary work does not make worship

unimportant; the rest precept does not condemn mercy, family care, or essential public service. General examples do not adjudicate every case.

What the canon does and does not say

It binds identified faithful to a common Eucharistic and festal practice. It specifies time, form, and certain relief. It does not establish a territorial list without particular law, govern Eastern Catholics through the Latin Code, decide every disputed fact, or pronounce the full culpability of a person from the external omission alone.

The Sunday precept is therefore an instance of responsive justice. The Church does not command God to become present or the Eucharist to become a private possession. She commands the faithful to enter the common act in which Christ gathers his body and gives what that body cannot supply for itself. Time received from God is returned as praise, rest, communion, and mercy—and received again as grace.

8 Failure Is Not Yet a Judgment of the Person

An objective obligation and personal culpability answer different questions. The first asks what act was due under the governing moral or legal norm. The second asks how a particular person failed, with what knowledge, freedom, intention, and circumstances. Keeping them distinct neither excuses wrongdoing nor permits judgment to outrun the facts.

The *Catechism* says that those who deliberately fail in the Sunday Eucharistic obligation commit a grave sin (CCC 2181). “Deliberately” cannot be discarded. Mortal sin requires grave matter, full knowledge, and deliberate consent together (CCC 1857). Knowledge must include the act’s sinful character; consent must be sufficiently complete for the act to be a personal choice (CCC 1859). Unintentional ignorance, external pressure, passions, or psychological disturbance can diminish or remove imputability, while chosen ignorance and malice can increase it (CCC 1860).

The resulting propositions are precise. Deliberate omission of the Sunday obligation without serious reason is objectively grave. Not every external absence is a deliberate omission. Not every genuine failure is committed with full knowledge and complete consent. A general article can identify the first proposition; it cannot infer the interior facts needed to pronounce the last judgment upon a named person. Although an act can be judged gravely disordered in itself, judgment of persons is entrusted to God’s justice and mercy (CCC 1861).

Canonical and moral effects must also remain distinct. Canon 1247 imposes an obligation. The article does not infer from every violation a canonical delict, penalty, sacramental incapacity, or public status. Moral gravity alone does not create a penal case. Conversely, the absence of a canonical penalty would not make the underlying obligation optional.

In a concrete case, the order of discernment matters: identify the governing law, the person bound, the act required, the material facts, and any applicable excuse, dispensation, or commutation before judging knowledge, consent, or other conditions of culpability. Beginning with subjective innocence can dissolve the norm before its good is seen. Beginning with the external failure and stopping there can mistake law for omniscience. Personal or doubtful cases belong with a pastor, confessor, competent authority, or qualified canonist who has the complete facts.

This is also why obligation should be taught from its object rather than principally from threatened punishment. Sunday protects the worship owed to God, the Eucharistic assembly, Paschal joy, mercy, and rest. The question “Must I?” deserves a truthful answer. It also deserves the prior answer to “What good is being commanded?” A precept whose good is never named will be heard as arbitrary even when its authority is real.

Yet understanding the good does not suspend obedience until every motive is emotionally compelling. The will can begin by doing what it knows is due. Habit can steady the act; worship can teach desire; grace can heal resistance. The moral life is not divided into a servile stage of rules and a later stage in which love makes justice obsolete. The movement is from an external word truly heard, through willing practice, toward an inward law that gives the act its mature form.

9 The Grace of the Answer

9.1 Justice opens into hope

The due exposes another asymmetry. No creature can repay creation, and no sinner can reach the supernatural end unaided. The first incapacity is permanent: no creature becomes equal to the Creator. The second is healed by grace. Justice therefore ends not by withdrawing the command but by hoping for the help that enables a filial act without making it unreal.

9.2 The office of hope

Here hope enters without becoming another name for justice. The *Catechism* says that when God reveals himself and calls, a person cannot fully respond to divine love by his own powers. He must hope that God will give the capacity to love in return and to act according to the commandments of charity (CCC 2090). Aquinas describes theological hope as tending toward future beatitude, arduous but possible through divine assistance (ST II–II, q. 17, aa. 1–2).

Justice names the answer owed. Hope refuses the fiction that the answer can be made alone.

Hope also excludes two evasions. Presumption appeals to mercy while refusing conversion, or trusts one's own powers as sufficient. Despair treats forgiveness, assistance, or beatitude as unavailable (CCC 2091–2092). Presumption says grace makes obedience unnecessary. Despair says obedience is futile because grace will not come. Neither receives gift as gift.

Devotion joins this hope to the will. Aquinas says meditation gives rise to devotion when one considers divine goodness and one's own insufficiency. The first awakens love; the second excludes presumption and makes the creature lean upon divine help. The resulting joy is joined to sorrow over present defect and to hope of assistance (ST II–II, q. 82, aa. 3–4). Proper abasement is therefore not paralysis. It is the truthful loss of self-sufficiency in a will made ready to act.

9.3 The living sacrifice

Psalm 116 asks the question in the language of thanksgiving: “How can I repay the Lord for all the good done for me?” Its answer is not a possession capable of equal exchange. The psalmist receives again: he raises the cup of salvation, calls upon the Lord's name, fulfills his vows among the people, and offers thanksgiving (Ps 116:12–19).

Paul's “therefore” can now bear its full weight: because no one first gives to God, and because all is mercy, offer your bodies as a living sacrifice (Rom 11:35–12:1). The body offered is already created; mercy already precedes the offering; the many who are members of Christ and of one another make the offering ecclesial (Rom 12:4–5). The return is real and entirely encompassed by gift.

Augustine calls every work ordered to holy fellowship with God a true sacrifice. The person becomes an offering; works of mercy are referred to the supreme good; the redeemed city is offered through the High Priest who first offered himself (*City of God* X.6). Christian sacrifice is therefore neither destruction for its own sake nor a tribute God consumes. In Christ it is the creature's whole life restored to right relation: reason renewed, body made available to good, neighbor received as fellow member, praise made common.

Gift received. Due recognized. Self offered.

The creature gives God nothing he lacks. It gives no equivalent for being, redemption, or glory. It gives the answer that justice can truly call due: body, reason, time, labor, praise, and service, offered through powers and mercies already received.

But justice has not yet spoken the last word. It has named what ought to be rendered; hope, by whose help. One question remains: can the will desire the good disclosed by duty—not merely as an order imposed by the highest Lord, but as communion with the beloved?

What is owed can be freely loved. What is freely loved does not cease to be owed. That movement belongs to charity.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and governing profiles

This is Part II of *The Creature Before God*, a discursive series for a serious general reader. Part I, *Ontological Vertigo*, treats the apprehension of asymmetric dependence. This article asks what is morally due once creaturely dependence is recognized, how obligation can be freely rendered, how Catholic tradition distinguishes the layers of law, and how current universal Latin law specifies the Sunday obligation. Part III treats charity and the perfection of the return.

The article deliberately combines theology and canon law under the discursive-articles profile. Metaphysics, Scripture, patristic witness, Thomistic moral theology, and authoritative Catholic teaching govern the account of gift, justice, religion, command, grace, hope, and charity. Canon law governs only the identified juridical conclusions. A theological reason does not by itself enact a canon; the existence of a canon does not settle every theological interpretation or personal culpability judgment.

“Due return,” “responsive justice,” and the five-term grammar of dependence, duty, precept, culpability, and counsel are project synthesis. *Religion* is used principally in Aquinas’s technical sense: the moral virtue annexed to justice that renders worship to God. It is not used as a synonym for the theological virtues or for every institutional feature of a religious body.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Sacred Scripture	Supplies creation and mercy before response, covenant before command, the Decalogue, worship and justice, the unrepayable gift, and the living sacrifice.	Exegetical synthesis remains bounded by the cited passages; no single verse is made a complete theory of law.
Patristic witness	Shows divine non-need, command for creaturely good, common Sunday worship, grace-enabled obedience, and self-offering in Christ.	Representative witnesses are not a mechanical consensus count or current legislation.
Thomistic theology	Provides justice, religion, unequal due, moral necessity without coercion, devotion, kinds of law, natural and positive determination, grace, hope, and charity’s formal role.	School theology and adopted synthesis remain distinct from dogma and current canon law.
Catechetical and conciliar teaching	Governs the doctrinal account of moral law, Church precepts, the Decalogue, the Lord’s Day, culpability, hope, worship, and common liturgical life.	The <i>Catechism</i> is authoritative teaching, not the promulgated text of the Latin Code.
Current Latin canon law	Establishes subjects, feast-day duties, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, and territorial competence.	The official Latin text, amendments, jurisdiction, particular law, and facts control; no individual case is adjudicated.
Project synthesis	Orders gift, due, precept, fault, hope, and self-offering into Part II of the series.	The terminology and literary movement are not attributed wholesale to any source.

A.2 Legal scope and currentness

Element	Controlling scope	Limit
Governing body of law	1983 Code of Canon Law as amended; universal law of the Latin Church.	CIC c. 1 excludes applying the Latin Code as such to Eastern Catholics; CCEO c. 881 and proper Eastern law are not analyzed.
Authoritative text and translation	Promulgated Latin and applicable later Latin legislation control; Holy See English pages are working reference renderings.	English wording does not displace the official text, canonical tradition, or a later promulgated norm.
Persons and territory	CIC cc. 1, 11–13 and 1246–1248; no named territory beyond universal law.	Other holy days, dispensations, and observance can depend upon episcopal-conference, diocesan, proper, or other applicable law.
Material facts	Abstract adult Latin Catholic with sufficient use of reason; no serious reason, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, privilege, or special law unless expressly discussed.	Real cases require complete facts and competent pastoral or canonical judgment.
Currentness	Official Code pages, the Holy See code and amendment archive, and the Holy See’s published compilation of authentic interpretations checked through 20 July 2026.	No located amendment or published authentic interpretation modified CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article. This bounded audit is not proof against unpublished or unexamined particular or proper law.
Advice boundary	General theological and canonical study.	Not legal or canonical advice, a decree, a culpability judgment, or a substitute for a pastor, confessor, competent authority, or qualified canonist.

A.3 Included and excluded scope

Included are Rom 11:33–12:2, Exod 19–20, Psalm 116, the Decalogue’s twofold order to God and neighbor, Irenaeus on divine non-need, Augustine on grace and living sacrifice, Justin on Sunday assembly, Aquinas on justice and religion, the architecture of law, devotion, grace and hope, the *Catechism*’s treatment of Church precepts and Sunday, *Sacrosanctum Concilium* 106, and current universal Latin law in CIC cc. 1, 11, 85–93, 1244–1248, and 912–923 where separately noted.

Excluded are a comprehensive treatise on moral theology, virtue, conscience, sin, sacramental theology, liturgy, ecclesiology, or canonical interpretation; a calendar of territorial holy days; national conference and diocesan norms; Eastern Catholic law beyond naming the boundary; obligations of clerics or religious arising from office, vows, constitutions, or proper law; remote-participation questions; Eucharistic reception in irregular or disputed circumstances; canonical penalties; and any judgment about a named person’s obligation, excuse, sin, or imputability.

The Sunday case is illustrative, not exhaustive. The Ten Commandments and the Latin Sunday precept do not stand at the same level of authority. The article does not flatten natural moral law, revealed divine law, and ecclesiastical positive law into one inventory.

A.4 Material qualifications

1. Creation is neither compelled by a lack in God nor antecedently owed to a recipient not yet existing. Genuine created dues arise within the order willed by divine wisdom (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3).
2. “Debt” and “return” are analogical, not commercial. No creature confers actuality, beatitude, or utility upon God or makes God a debtor by worship.
3. Religion is a moral virtue annexed to justice because worship is due but cannot be rendered in absolute equality. It is not itself faith, hope, or charity (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 5).

4. The necessity of command differs from physical or psychological constraint. Obligation does not eliminate voluntariness, while external compliance alone does not constitute complete virtue.
5. Natural reason grounds worship generically; determinate rites and times can arise from divine or human positive law (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3; q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).
6. The Decalogue is revealed and expresses natural moral law. Its moral substance, its covenantal promulgation, and its ceremonial or juridical determinations must be distinguished.
7. Sunday fulfills the Sabbath’s spiritual truth in the Paschal mystery; it is not identified with every Mosaic Sabbath determination (CCC 2174–2176).
8. CIC c. 1247 contains both Mass participation and festal-rest duties. The latter is governed by what impedes worship, joy, works of mercy, and appropriate rest, not by a universal ban on all work.
9. Participation in Mass and reception of Holy Communion are distinct juridical and sacramental questions. CIC cc. 912–923 govern reception; this article decides no sacramental-access case.
10. Excuse, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation have different grounds and effects. Private preference is not competent dispensation.
11. Objective grave matter and mortal culpability are distinct. Full knowledge and deliberate consent must be established; a general article cannot judge a person’s soul (CCC 1857–1861).
12. Violation of a moral or disciplinary norm does not without an applicable penal norm establish a canonical delict or penalty.
13. Hope is not a species of justice. It trusts divine assistance for the arduous supernatural good; presumption and despair each falsify that trust.
14. Grace does not abolish command or secondary agency. The New Law’s inward gift heals and elevates the person to act freely (ST I–II, q. 106, aa. 1–2).
15. Charity perfects and commands the acts of other virtues by ordering them to the final end. It does not make injustice or impiety optional (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 8).

A.5 Translations, rights, and review

Scripture is cited by book and locus, with short working-English phrases checked against the Holy See-hosted NAB witness. Patristic working English comes from identified public-domain ANF or NPNF witnesses. Aquinas is cited by work, part, question, article, and reply; Latin loci are governed by the Corpus Thomisticum, with public English used as an aid. Official Catholic and canonical texts retain their own status. No bulk source text, modern commentary, or source-site wrapper is incorporated.

Online witnesses and mutable law were checked through 20 July 2026. This source-audited working study has completed internal PDF production review. It has not received independent scriptural, patristic, Thomistic, moral-theological, liturgical, canonical, literary, or ecclesiastical review. It claims no imprimatur, nihil obstat, legal opinion, or ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Exod 19:3–6 and 20:1–17; Deut 5:1–22; Psalm 116:1–19, especially vv. 12–19; Matt 22:34–40; John 14:15; Rom 11:33–12:5 and 13:8–10; Jas 1:22–27; 1 John 4:19–21 and 5:3. Short English wording is used as a working rendering; Scripture and translations retain their own status.
- Holy See-hosted New American Bible working witnesses: Exodus 20, Psalm 116, Romans 11, and Romans 12.

Authoritative Catholic witnesses

- Second Vatican Council, constitution *Sacrosanctum Concilium* (4 December 1963), nos. 7, 10–12, 14, and 106, especially the Lord’s Day as the original feast and the faithful’s liturgical participation; official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1730–1748 (freedom and responsibility); 1854–1864 (grave matter and culpability); 1950–1974 (eternal, natural, old, and new law); 2030–2043 (the Church’s moral teaching and precepts); 2060–2082 (covenant, Decalogue, and natural law); 2084–2100 (faith, hope, charity, adoration, prayer, and sacrifice); 2168–2195, especially 2174–2187 (Sabbath, Lord’s Day, Sunday obligation, serious reason, rest, and mercy). Official English pages: culpability, moral law, Church precepts, faith, hope, and charity, and the Lord’s Day.
- St. John Paul II, apostolic letter *Dies Domini* (31 May 1998), especially nos. 6–8, 18–20, 31–34, and 46–53, on the Paschal, ecclesial, moral, and juridical dimensions of Sunday; official English.

Patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2, on divine non-need, service for the creature’s good, and fellowship with God; IV.17.1 and 18.1–6, on sacrifice, justice, and offerings that do not supply a divine need. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s 1885 ANF working English: IV.14, IV.17, and IV.18.
- St. Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 67, on the Sunday assembly, Scripture, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving and Communion, and care of those in need; Marcus Dods and George Reith’s 1885 ANF working English, online witness.
- Augustine, *City of God* X.1, 3, 5–6, and 19–20, on *latria*, true religion, outward signs, every work ordered to holy fellowship with God as sacrifice, the redeemed city offered through Christ, and God as needing no offering; public-domain NPNF working English, online witness.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 21, a. 1, especially ad 2–3, and a. 4, ad 4, on divine justice, derivative created dues, and God as no debtor to creatures; q. 44, a. 4, on God as final cause.
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I–II, q. 90, aa. 1–4; q. 91, aa. 1–5; q. 94, aa. 1–6 (law, its kinds, and natural law); q. 100, aa. 1, 3, 7, and 8 (the Decalogue, natural law, the two tablets, and moral versus determinate observance); q. 106, aa. 1–2 (the New Law chiefly as inward grace); q. 108, a. 4 (precepts and counsels); q. 109, especially aa. 2–4 and 8 (the need of grace).
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* II–II, q. 17, aa. 1–2 (hope and divine assistance); q. 23, a. 8 (charity as form of the virtues); q. 58, aa. 1–4, especially a. 3, ad 2 (justice and necessity of command without constraint); q. 80, a. 1 and q. 81, aa. 1–7 (religion as an unequal part of justice, its acts, and relation to the theological virtues); q. 82, aa. 1–4 (devotion, meditation, joy, and hope); q. 85, aa. 1–4 (sacrifice and natural versus positive determination); q. 122, a. 4 (the Sabbath precept).
- Governing Latin loci checked through the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus. The New Advent Summa served as a working public English index; particularly relevant English aids include justice, religion, devotion, the Decalogue, and the New Law. Work and exact locus control over either site’s wording.

Current Latin canon law

- John Paul II, apostolic constitution *Sacrae disciplinae leges* (25 January 1983) and the 1983 *Codex Iuris Canonici* as amended. CIC c. 1 (Latin jurisdiction); cc. 7–22, especially 11–18 (promulgation, persons bound, territory, doubt, interpretation); cc. 85–93 (dispensations); cc. 912–923 (Eucharistic reception); and cc. 1244–1248 (sacred times, feast days, obligation, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation).
- Official Latin: Book I and Book IV. Holy See-hosted working English: cc. 7–22, cc. 35–93, and cc. 1244–1253.
- Currentness controls checked through 20 July 2026: Holy See Code and amendment archive; Dicastery for Legislative Texts, published compilation of authentic interpretations. No located act amended or authentically interpreted CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article.
- Eastern boundary only: CCEO c. 881 contains the Eastern common-law feast-day obligation and preserves the prescriptions or legitimate customs of each Church *sui iuris*. It is not analyzed or replaced by the Latin canons in this article.

C Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-21T02:58:45Z

Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (theological, Thomistic, patristic, canonical, source-audit, drafting, and editorial roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

Reuse and rights. To the extent Triptych holds the rights, project-created content and design are licensed under CC BY 4.0. Scripture, liturgical or official texts, received prayers or hymns, quotations, fonts, and other third-party material retain their own status; public-domain material remains public domain. Identify changes. Attribution implies neither Triptych nor ecclesiastical approval. See **LICENSE** and **THIRD_PARTY.md** in the source.